

FAMILY STUDIES

OVERVIEW

In the social sciences and humanities curriculum, family studies is a multidisciplinary subject area that encompasses four areas: fashion and housing; food and nutrition; general family studies; and raising and caring for children. The topics covered in these areas include, among others: textile production; the functions and design of clothing; the fashion industry; issues related to housing; interior design; the role of nutrition in health; the relationship between food and culture; human and family interactions and development; life management skills; various types of relationships; and considerations related to raising and caring for children.

In family studies courses, students learn about laws and policies that affect individuals and families in Canada and around the world. They also become familiar with the theoretical perspectives and practical research that underpin our understandings of individual and family development. Family studies courses also integrate theory and practical skills. Many expectations can be achieved through practical experiences both in the classroom and in co-op placements, some of which may be affiliated with Specialist High Skills Majors programs.

All courses in family studies encourage students to develop critical and creative thinking skills. Students are given opportunities to deepen their understanding of relevant issues and to develop practical skills, including research and inquiry skills. Students are encouraged to explore a range of perspectives and approaches and to develop the habits of mind that enhance individual, family, and community well-being and contribute to lifelong learning.

GENERAL FAMILY STUDIES

Families in Canada, Grade 12

College Preparation

HHS4C

This course enables students to develop an understanding of social science theories as they apply to individual development, the development of intimate relationships, and family and parent-child relationships. Students will explore a range of issues relating to the development of individuals and families in contemporary Canadian society as well as in other cultures and historical periods. They will develop the investigative skills required to conduct research on individuals, intimate relationships, and parent-child roles and relationships in Canada.

Prerequisite: Any university, college, or university/college preparation course in social sciences and humanities, English, or Canadian and world studies

A. RESEARCH AND INQUIRY SKILLS

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

Throughout this course, students will:

- A1. Exploring:** explore topics related to families in Canada, and formulate questions to guide their research;
- A2. Investigating:** create research plans, and locate and select information relevant to their chosen topics, using appropriate and social science research and inquiry methods;
- A3. Processing Information:** assess, record, analyse, and synthesize information gathered through research and inquiry;
- A4. Communicating and Reflecting:** communicate the results of their research and inquiry clearly and effectively, and reflect on and evaluate their research, inquiry, and communication skills.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

A1. Exploring

Throughout this course, students will:

- A1.1** explore a variety of topics related to families in Canada (*e.g., the division of labour in families, the effects of different custody arrangements on children, the pressures and joys experienced in interfaith marriages, the impact of the Indian Act on First Nation families*) to identify topics for research and inquiry
- A1.2** identify key concepts (*e.g., through discussion, brainstorming, use of visual organizers*) related to their selected topics
- A1.3** formulate effective questions to guide their research and inquiry
Teacher prompt: “If you were researching the ways in which families divide household labour, why might it be useful to compare families with and without children?”

A2. Investigating

Throughout this course, students will:

- A2.1** create appropriate research plans to investigate their selected topics (*e.g., outline purpose and method; identify sources of information; develop research tools such as surveys, questionnaires, or interviews*), ensuring that their plans follow guidelines for ethical research

- A2.2** locate and select information relevant to their investigations from a variety of primary sources (*e.g., interviews; observations; surveys and questionnaires; original research published in peer-reviewed journals; census data; original documents in print or other media, such as film, photographs*) and secondary sources (*e.g., textbooks, book reviews, literature reviews, magazine or newspaper articles*)

Teacher prompts: “What is the difference between a primary and a secondary source? How can you determine whether a source is primary or secondary?” “Why is it important to base your research on a variety of sources?”

- A2.3** based on preliminary research, for each investigation formulate a hypothesis, thesis statement, or research question, and use it to focus their research

A3. Processing Information

Throughout this course, students will:

- A3.1** assess various aspects of information gathered from primary and secondary sources (*e.g., accuracy, relevance, reliability, inherent values and bias, voice*)

Teacher prompts: “What strategies can you use to determine the relevance of the information you have gathered?” “If two information sources contradict each other, how might you determine which is more reliable?”

A3.2 record and organize information and key ideas using a variety of formats (*e.g., notes, graphic organizers, summaries, audio/digital records*)

A3.3 analyse and interpret research information (*e.g., compare results of interviews with different groups; determine whether common themes arise in different sources; compare results from primary data sources with results reported in secondary sources*)

A3.4 demonstrate academic honesty by documenting the sources of all information generated through research

A3.5 synthesize findings and formulate conclusions (*e.g., determine whether their results support or contradict their hypothesis; weigh and connect information to determine the answer to their research question*)

A4. Communicating and Reflecting

Throughout this course, students will:

A4.1 use an appropriate format (*e.g., oral presentation, poster, multimedia presentation, web page*) to communicate the results of their research and inquiry effectively for a specific purpose and audience

A4.2 use terms relating to families in Canada correctly (*e.g., family systems, life expectancy, replacement rate, primary and secondary research, socialization*)

A4.3 clearly communicate the results of their inquiries (*e.g., write clearly, organize ideas logically, use language conventions properly*), and follow APA conventions for acknowledging sources (*e.g., generate a reference list in APA style*)

A4.4 demonstrate an understanding of the general research process by reflecting on and evaluating their own research, inquiry, and communication skills

Teacher prompts: “In what ways did the primary and/or secondary sources you used confirm what you already knew and understood about the topic? In what ways did these sources contradict what you thought was true?”
 “How might the research methods you used have affected the results you obtained?”
 “What steps might you take to enhance your research/inquiry skills?”

B. THEORETICAL PERSPECTIVES ON DEVELOPMENT

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- B1. Individual Development:** demonstrate an understanding of theoretical perspectives and research on various aspects of individual development;
- B2. The Development of Intimate Relationships:** demonstrate an understanding of theoretical perspectives and research on the development of intimate relationships;
- B3. The Development of Family and Parent-Child Relationships:** demonstrate an understanding of theoretical perspectives and research on the development of family and parent-child relationships.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

B1. Individual Development

By the end of this course, students will:

- B1.1** describe individual development throughout the lifespan, according to a variety of theoretical perspectives on development (e.g., psychodynamic perspective [Sigmund Freud, Erik Erikson, Karen Horney], cognitive perspective [Lev Vygotsky], humanist perspective [Abraham Maslow, Carl Rogers], symbolic interactionist perspective [Charles Cooley, George Mead], sociocultural perspective [Urie Bronfenbrenner], evolutionary perspective [Konrad Lorenz, John Bowlby])

Teacher prompt: “According to the humanist perspective, what are the major factors contributing to individual development?”

- B1.2** describe research on sex-based similarities and differences and on gender-based similarities and differences (e.g., similarities and differences related to socialization, findings and limitations of brain research)

Teacher prompt: “What have researchers discovered about the differences in the ways that male and female infants tend to be treated?”

- B1.3** describe theories used to explain adult development in later life (e.g., Erik Erikson’s stages of generativity versus stagnation, and

ego integrity versus despair; Bernice Neugarten’s concept of the social clock; George Mead’s symbolic interactionist theories)

Teacher prompt: “According to Erikson’s theory, what factors lead to the greatest satisfaction in later life?”

B2. The Development of Intimate Relationships

By the end of this course, students will:

- B2.1** summarize how various theoretical perspectives (e.g., psychodynamic, evolutionary, structural functionalist, conflict theory, feminist theory, queer theory perspectives) explain the development of intimate relationships

Teacher prompt: “What key concepts do structural functionalists use to explain how and why intimate relationships develop in specific ways?”

- B2.2** describe various theories of attraction and mate selection (e.g., evolutionary theory, filter theory, social homogamy theory, the theory of complementary needs)

Teacher prompt: “According to evolutionary theory, what determines whether two people will be attracted to one another?”

B2.3 describe current research that supports or contradicts various theories of attraction, mate selection, and the development of intimate relationships

Teacher prompt: “Which theories of attraction are best supported by the results of recent research?”

B3. The Development of Family and Parent-Child Relationships

By the end of this course, students will:

B3.1 describe the functions of families (*e.g., reproduction, socialization of children, physical maintenance of members, nurturance and love, social control, production of goods and services*)

B3.2 explain the development of family and parent-child relationships from the viewpoint of a variety of theoretical perspectives (*e.g.,*

symbolic interactionist, family systems, conflict theory, feminist theory, structural functionalist perspectives)

Teacher prompt: “How do family systems theorists explain cohesion and family conflict?”

B3.3 describe the impact of caregiving on family relationships in a variety of contexts (*e.g., with reference to the sandwich generation, the revolving door, skipped-generation or grandparent-led families, blended families, single-parent families, families with members who have special needs*)

Teacher prompts: “What are the positive and negative effects on parents when adult children move back home? What are the effects on the adult children?” “What are the typical stresses and benefits experienced by caregivers looking after a spouse with Alzheimer’s disease?” “What are the stresses and benefits experienced by children and grandchildren when an aging parent/grandparent moves in?”

C. THE IMPACT OF NORMS, ROLES, AND INSTITUTIONS

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- C1. The Effects on Individuals:** demonstrate an understanding of the impact of norms, roles, and social institutions on individuals throughout the lifespan;
- C2. The Effects on Intimate Relationships:** demonstrate an understanding of the impact of norms, roles, and social institutions on intimate relationships;
- C3. The Effects on Family and Parent-Child Relationships:** demonstrate an understanding of factors that can affect decisions about whether to have and how to care for children, and of the impact of norms, roles, and social institutions on family and parent-child relationships.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

C1. The Effects on Individuals

By the end of this course, students will:

- C1.1** explain ways in which norms, values, and expectations (*e.g., cultural and societal norms and expectations, gender expectations, familial values and expectations*) influence individual decisions throughout the lifespan (*e.g., with regard to educational choices, career choices, choices about sexuality and relationships*)
Teacher prompt: “In what ways can familial or cultural expectations influence an individual’s career choices?”
- C1.2** explain how multiple roles (*e.g., student, volunteer, employee, friend, son/daughter, sibling, caregiver*) can create personal conflict
Teacher prompt: “What are some strategies for establishing and maintaining a balance between your schoolwork, part-time employment, and social life?”
- C1.3** explain the impact of social institutions (*e.g., the family; the media; educational, religious, economic, and political institutions*) on the socialization of individuals throughout the lifespan
Teacher prompts: “How do the media contribute to Western consumer values? What impact do these values have on the behaviour of adolescents?” “What are some common age- or gender-related rites or regulations among major religions? How might they affect the behaviour or choices of individuals?”

C2. The Effects on Intimate Relationships

By the end of this course, students will:

- C2.1** explain how social norms and expectations (*e.g., cultural and religious norms; expectations of peers, friends, parents*) can influence the establishment and maintenance of healthy intimate relationships
Teacher prompt: “How might norms associated with an extended family affect the development of intimate relationships?”
- C2.2** describe mate-selection, courtship, and marriage customs (*e.g., arranged and free-choice marriages; use of matchmakers; civil, religious, and tribal marriage ceremonies; polygamy and monogamy*) in various cultures, religions, and historical periods
Teacher prompt: “In what ways are marriage customs in contemporary Ojibwe communities similar to and different from Judaeo-Christian marriage customs?”
- C2.3** describe ways in which roles are negotiated in intimate relationships (*e.g., with reference to division of labour, patterns of authority*)
Teacher prompts: “What are some areas in which intimate partners commonly have to negotiate their roles?” “How might differences between the respective incomes of the two partners affect their roles in an intimate relationship?”

C2.4 describe differences among roles in intimate relationships in various social, historical, and ethnocultural contexts (e.g., in traditional Islamic and Hindu societies; in First Nation or Inuit cultures; before and after the second wave women's movement in Canada)

Teacher prompt: "What are the differences in the roles of the individuals involved in courtship practices in societies that practise free-choice marriage and those that practise arranged marriage?"

C2.5 explain how social institutions (e.g., religious, economic, political institutions) can affect intimate relationships

Teacher prompt: "How do state definitions of the term spouse affect the rights of and social supports available to couples?"

C3. The Effects on Family and Parent-Child Relationships

By the end of this course, students will:

C3.1 describe a range of factors that can influence decisions about having children (e.g., fertility; access to assisted reproductive technologies; access to birth control; religious beliefs regarding birth control and abortion; adoption policies and practices; the stability of an intimate relationship; considerations regarding the number and spacing of children; age and health; financial status; educational, career, and personal goals; cultural/religious background; the influence of friends or family; concerns about over-consumption of resources)

Teacher prompt: "What types of reproductive technologies are available for people wishing to have children? Do all people have equal access to these technologies?"

C3.2 identify and describe the caregivers and the ways in which caregiving responsibilities are carried out (e.g., the sex of the caregiver; whether the caregiving is paid work; the extent to which children, grandparents, or other relatives are involved) in diverse families (e.g., working-class and upper-middle-class families, single-parent and extended families, grandparent-led families)

Teacher prompts: "How do the responsibilities of children and teens in single-parent families compare to those in two-parent families?" "What proportion of caregiving work in Canada is provided by paid live-in caregivers wishing to immigrate to Canada?"

C3.3 describe government policy and legislation that is intended to support and protect families (e.g., parental and maternity leave benefits, protection from discrimination on the grounds of family status, protection against discrimination because of pregnancy, the right to breastfeed in public, adoption rights for same-sex couples, subsidized childcare, grandparents' rights)

Teacher prompts: "What does it mean to have 'family status' as a protected ground in the Ontario Human Rights Code?" "What rights do grandparents in Ontario and elsewhere in Canada have with respect to access to and visitation with grandchildren after a divorce?"

C3.4 describe the role of the family as an agent of socialization in different cultures and historical periods and among groups from various religious backgrounds (e.g., with reference to child-rearing practices, parental expectations, attitudes towards sexuality, education, gender socialization)

Teacher prompt: "What role did parents play in the socialization of children and adolescents in the Middle Ages?"

C3.5 compare the roles of children in the family and society in various cultures and historical periods (e.g., with reference to rites of passage, participation in education and the labour force, the nature of parent-child relationships, attitudes towards family members with special needs)

Teacher prompt: "Why do some social scientists argue that adolescence is a by-product of industrialization? What was the role of adolescents before industrialization?"

C3.6 explain the impact of social institutions (e.g., educational, religious, economic, political institutions) on the socialization of family members

Teacher prompt: "Which institution has the greater role to play in the socialization of children – school or family? Give reasons to support your answer."

D. TRENDS, ISSUES, AND CHALLENGES

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- D1. Trends and Challenges for Individuals:** demonstrate an understanding of demographic trends related to the lives of individuals, and of the impact of social issues and challenges on individual development;
- D2. Trends and Challenges in Intimate Relationships:** demonstrate an understanding of demographic and social trends and issues related to intimate relationships, and of strategies for responding to challenges in those relationships;
- D3. Trends and Challenges in the Family and in Parent-Child Relationships:** demonstrate an understanding of demographic trends related to the family and to parent-child relationships, and of the impact of social issues and challenges on family development.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

D1. Trends and Challenges for Individuals

By the end of this course, students will:

- D1.1** describe recent demographic trends relating to the lives of individuals (*e.g., trends related to educational attainment, workforce participation, income, independent living, age at retirement, life expectancy, rates of cancer and other serious diseases*)

Teacher prompt: “What is the life expectancy of males and females in Canada today? How does this compare to life expectancy twenty-five years ago?”

- D1.2** explain the impact of current social trends, issues, and challenges on individual development (*e.g., with reference to electronic media, climate change, increased life expectancy, health care, education, economic changes, increased urbanization*)

Teacher prompt: “What impact does an increasingly knowledge-based economy have on the educational requirements for entry-level employment? What impact have these requirements had on the age at which individuals ‘launch’ from their family home?”

D2. Trends and Challenges in Intimate Relationships

By the end of this course, students will:

- D2.1** describe recent demographic trends relating to intimate relationships (*e.g., with regard to adolescent sexual activity; cohabitation, marriage, and divorce rates; same-sex marriage; delayed age of marriage; an increase in the number of people living independently; serial monogamy; an increase in arranged marriages*)

Teacher prompts: “How has the divorce rate changed in Canada over the past twenty-five years?” “What changes in income do women tend to experience after divorce? How do they compare to changes in the income of divorced men?”

- D2.2** explain the impact of current social trends, issues, and challenges on intimate relationships (*e.g., with reference to electronic media, employment, health care, education, economic changes, the aging population, balancing work and family, an increase in the number of relationships between people of different faiths or ethnic backgrounds*)

Teacher prompt: “How has the Internet changed dating practices in the West?”

D2.3 outline strategies for avoiding and responding to various types of violence and abuse in intimate relationships (e.g., emotional, physical, sexual, financial abuse)

Teacher prompt: “What community agencies are available to support women who are leaving violent relationships?”

D3. Trends and Challenges in the Family and in Parent-Child Relationships

By the end of this course, students will:

D3.1 describe the impact of major social and economic changes on the historical evolution of the family (e.g., with reference to complementary roles for men, women, and children in peasant families in agricultural economies; family relations in slave economies; male breadwinners and stay-at-home mothers and children in middle-class families and child labour in working-class families in industrializing economies; the impact on child labour of the development of compulsory education policies; changes in child-rearing practices)

Teacher prompts: “In what ways did the process of industrialization affect the evolution of the family and people’s roles in it?” “Currently, what percentage of married women in Canada work outside the home? How does this figure compare to that from 100 years ago or to figures from other countries around the world?”

D3.2 describe recent demographic trends relating to parent-child relationships (e.g., with reference to family forms, birth rates, age at childbearing, child custody arrangements, caregiving responsibilities, life expectancy, employment status of family members, educational attainment)

Teacher prompt: “What do statistics from the past ten years show about how child custody arrangements have changed in Canada?”

D3.3 explain the impact of current social trends, issues, and challenges relating to the functioning of families (e.g., with reference to electronic media, climate change, health care, education, economic conditions, the aging of the population, balancing work and family, increasing ethnocultural and religious diversity in Canada)

Teacher prompts: “What challenges and opportunities do electronic media present to families? Do electronic media generally increase or decrease the time that family members spend with each other?” “How has the moratorium on cod fishing affected family roles in Atlantic Canada?”

D3.4 describe the impact of violence and abuse on family relationships (e.g., with reference to victims and witnesses of child abuse and neglect, spousal/partner abuse, elder abuse and neglect)

Teacher prompt: “What is elder abuse? What are the different forms that such abuse can take? What impact can such abuse have?”